TAKE IT HOME

Research Administration and AI: A Discussion Instrument

Sixteen statements about AI in research administration, with a guide for running a facilitated conversation about them. Free to use and adapt under a Creative Commons license.

WHAT THIS IS

Built to start a conversation

The instrument is a set of sixteen statements. Participants say how much they agree with each one, and then a facilitator leads a discussion of where the group agrees and where it splits. It is not a survey, and it is not meant to measure attitudes.

The statements use strong words on purpose: “always,” “must,” “never.” A mild statement gets mild agreement and leaves nothing to talk about. A strong one makes people take a side, and when they explain why, you learn what they actually care about. The statements come in four modules, which help separate the reasons people hesitate about AI: know-how, values and risk, what “AI literacy” means, and wider economic and environmental costs.

We wrote the instrument for dialogue workshops with research administrators in spring 2026. This version was prepared for participants in the AI4RA workshop at the NCURA Region VI/VII Regional Meeting in Denver, November 2026.

> WHO SHOULD FACILITATE
>
> ## Free to use. Best with a trained facilitator.
>
> The instrument is free. Ideally, the person who facilitates has training in ethics, philosophy, or a related field. The statements are designed to provoke, and a trained facilitator keeps the disagreement useful: they help the group tell apart disagreements about facts, about values, and about what a word means, and they test arguments without steering the room toward their own view.
>
> If no one in your office has that background, a colleague from a philosophy or ethics program on your campus may be glad to help. Either way, the facilitator should not be anyone’s supervisor.

FACILITATOR GUIDE

How to run a session

Before

- Choose your statements. All sixteen take about 10 to 15 minutes to answer. For a shorter session, use one module, or three or four statements.
- You can write your own statements about a decision your office faces. Keep the strong words.
- Find a neutral facilitator. Small groups work best.

During

- Participation is voluntary. Anyone can pass on any statement.
- Everyone responds privately before anyone speaks. Use the sheet, a show of hands (one to five fingers, a fist for "I don't know"), or an anonymous poll.
- Show the group's spread, then discuss. Keep responses anonymous.
- "I Don't Know" and "N/A" are real answers. Count them.

After

- Write down the reasoning, not just the result. A future colleague will need to know why you decided what you did.
- Many "I Don't Know" answers on one statement usually point to information your institution could supply.
- Run it again later. Positions change as the tools and policies do.

Questions for the discussion

- **Where does the disagreement live?** In the facts (what is the case), in values (what ought to be the case), or in words (what a key term means)?
- **Which word in the statement is doing the work?** Try the statement without "always" or "never." Does your answer change?
- **What would change your mind?** If you can't name anything, the position hasn't been tested yet.
- **Is someone arguing by analogy?** ("Using AI here is like using a form letter.") Look for a relevant difference: a difference between the two cases that matters for the conclusion.
- **Where did your own answer surprise you?** Where did the group's?

FACILITATOR GUIDE

What each module is for

MODULE A · STATEMENTS 1 TO 4

Technical competency and methodology

Finds out whether hesitancy comes from a lack of technical confidence or know-how. Many "I Don't Know" answers here point to a literacy gap.

To what extent does effective research administration require technical proficiency in AI?

MODULE B · STATEMENTS 5 TO 8

Ethical values and risk

Finds out whether hesitancy comes from moral obligation or from risk aversion. These statements force a trade-off between efficiency and correctness.

Do ethical risks outweigh the efficiency gains of AI in research administration?

MODULE C · STATEMENTS 9 TO 11

Defining “AI literacy”

Works on a messy concept. The statements are ambiguous on purpose, so the group has to negotiate a shared definition.

What constitutes “literacy” in the context of automated administration?

MODULE D · STATEMENTS 12 TO 16

Economic and environmental impact

Finds out whether hesitancy comes from wider concerns, such as job security or climate change, rather than day-to-day workflow or skills. It separates a “local” worry (I can’t do this task) from a “global” one (this task shouldn’t exist).

To what extent should global economic and environmental factors influence local administrative decisions?

Module D often draws “I Don’t Know.” These resources ground the environmental conversation in real data: what-uses-more.com (energy and water costs of everyday digital activities), your-digital-life.org (the footprint of your own digital habits), and the University of Idaho’s GPU telemetry analysis (the footprint of one campus AI cluster).

HOW TO CREDIT US

Attribution and license

The instrument was developed by Bert Baumgaertner (Department of Philosophy) with the AI4RA project team at the University of Idaho, led by Sarah Martonick. AI4RA is supported by the U.S. National Science Foundation.

When you use or adapt it, please credit it like this:

> “Research Administration and AI: A Discussion Instrument” by Bert Baumgaertner and the AI4RA project team, University of Idaho (Sarah Martonick, principal investigator), 2026. Supported by NSF Award No. 2427549. Licensed under CC BY-NC-SA 4.0. If you changed it, add: “Adapted by [your name or office].”

© 2026 Bert Baumgaertner and the AI4RA project, University of Idaho. This work is licensed under the Creative Commons Attribution-NonCommercial-ShareAlike 4.0 International License. You may copy, share, and adapt it for non-commercial purposes, as long as you give credit, say whether you made changes, and share your adapted version under the same license.

This material is based upon work supported by the National Science Foundation under Award No. 2427549. Any opinions, findings, and conclusions or recommendations expressed in this material are those of the authors and do not necessarily reflect the views of the National Science Foundation.

Questions, or want to tell us how it went? Contact Bert Baumgaertner at bbaum@uidaho.edu.
More from the project at ai4ra.uidaho.edu. This version: October 21, 2026.

Research Administration and AI

PARTICIPANT SHEET

For each statement, mark the box that best fits your first reaction. There are no right answers. The statements are strong on purpose. You can mark “I Don’t Know” or “N/A,” or skip any statement. Please don’t write your name on this sheet.

Module A. Technical competency and methodology

To what extent does effective research administration require technical proficiency in AI?

1 **A research administrator must understand the underlying algorithms of an AI tool to use it responsibly.**

☐ Disagree ☐ Somewhat Disagree ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat Agree ☐ Agree ☐ I Don’t Know ☐ N/A

2 **If an administrator cannot verify the output of an AI tool manually, they should never use that tool for grant submissions.**

☐ Disagree ☐ Somewhat Disagree ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat Agree ☐ Agree ☐ I Don’t Know ☐ N/A

3 **Technical skill in “prompt engineering” is now a fundamental requirement for the research administrator role.**

☐ Disagree ☐ Somewhat Disagree ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat Agree ☐ Agree ☐ I Don’t Know ☐ N/A

4 **Human error is a greater risk to research compliance than AI “hallucinations” or software errors.**

☐ Disagree ☐ Somewhat Disagree ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat Agree ☐ Agree ☐ I Don’t Know ☐ N/A

Module B. Ethical values and risk

Do ethical risks outweigh the efficiency gains of AI in research administration?

5 **Efficiency in processing grants always justifies the use of AI, even if the internal process is opaque.**

☐ Disagree ☐ Somewhat Disagree ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat Agree ☐ Agree ☐ I Don’t Know ☐ N/A

6 **An AI-generated report is valid as long as the data is accurate, regardless of how the AI model was trained.**

☐ Disagree ☐ Somewhat Disagree ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat Agree ☐ Agree ☐ I Don’t Know ☐ N/A

7 **It is unethical to utilize AI for drafting internal communications without explicitly disclosing it to the recipients.**

☐ Disagree ☐ Somewhat Disagree ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat Agree ☐ Agree ☐ I Don’t Know ☐ N/A

8 **Protecting institutional data privacy is always more important than adopting tools that speed up workflow.**

☐ Disagree ☐ Somewhat Disagree ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat Agree ☐ Agree ☐ I Don’t Know ☐ N/A

Module C. Defining “AI literacy”

What constitutes “literacy” in the context of automated administration?

9 **High AI literacy is more important for modern research administrators than knowledge of institutional policy.**

☐ Disagree ☐ Somewhat Disagree ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat Agree ☐ Agree ☐ I Don’t Know ☐ N/A

10 **An administrator is “AI literate” only if they can identify when an AI output is biased or incorrect.**

☐ Disagree ☐ Somewhat Disagree ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat Agree ☐ Agree ☐ I Don’t Know ☐ N/A

11 **“AI Literacy” is the responsibility of the IT department, not the individual research administrator.**

☐ Disagree ☐ Somewhat Disagree ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat Agree ☐ Agree ☐ I Don’t Know ☐ N/A

Module D. Economic and environmental impact

To what extent should global economic and environmental factors influence local administrative decisions?

12 **The preservation of administrative jobs must always take precedence over the cost-savings offered by AI automation.**

☐ Disagree ☐ Somewhat Disagree ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat Agree ☐ Agree ☐ I Don’t Know ☐ N/A

13 **Research administrators are ethically complicit in environmental harm when they use energy-intensive large language models (LLMs).**

☐ Disagree ☐ Somewhat Disagree ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat Agree ☐ Agree ☐ I Don’t Know ☐ N/A

14 **The operational efficiency gained from AI always justifies its environmental footprint.**

☐ Disagree ☐ Somewhat Disagree ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat Agree ☐ Agree ☐ I Don’t Know ☐ N/A

15 **AI tools will eventually replace the need for human research administrators entirely.**

☐ Disagree ☐ Somewhat Disagree ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat Agree ☐ Agree ☐ I Don’t Know ☐ N/A

16 **It is not the responsibility of a research administrator to consider the global economic impact of the software tools they use.**

☐ Disagree ☐ Somewhat Disagree ☐ Neutral ☐ Somewhat Agree ☐ Agree ☐ I Don’t Know ☐ N/A

“Research Administration and AI: A Discussion Instrument” by Bert Baumgaertner and the AI4RA project team, University of Idaho (Sarah Martonick, PI). Supported by NSF Award No. 2427549. CC BY-NC-SA 4.0. ui-insight.github.io/NCURARegionalWorkshop2026/instrument.html